Varanasi told our reporter, *‘Modiji toh desh ko bachane aaye hain!’* (Modi is here to save the country.) He could well have been echoing a dialogue from a Bachchan film.

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I arrived in Varanasi in the first week of May to shoot a ground report. The campaign was at its peak. BJP leaders and workers were everywhere. In the hotel where I was staying, I bumped into Gordhan Zadaphia, the Gujarat politician who had once rebelled against Modi but had now quietly returned to the fold. I asked him what he was doing in Varanasi. ‘I have been assigned the task of reaching out to Gujarati voters in the city,’ he told me. The reality was that every BJP leader, big or small, needed to put in an obligatory face show before the all-powerful Modi–Shah duo. ‘We had so many leaders assembled in one place, we didn’t know what work to give them!’ one of the BJP’s campaign coordinators admitted to me later.

On the streets, the BJP’s war cry, ‘*Har Har Modi, Ghar Ghar Modi*’, was proving contentious. The Dwarka Shankaracharya had objected, claiming that the chanting amounted to deification of Modi and was against Hindu religion. Modi had even tweeted asking his supporters not to use the slogan. And yet, when we were filming with BJP–RSS workers out canvassing on a door-to-door campaign, we heard the chant repeatedly. The moment I raised the issue with the party workers, they quickly changed the slogan. ‘Har Har Modi’ was dropped, ‘Ghar Ghar Modi’ remained in place! I am sure when our camera team left the site, the original chant would have returned. As an overenthusiastic worker told me: ‘You can say what you want, Modi *hamare liye Bhagwaan barabar hai*!’ (Modi is like God for us.)

An entire floor in the Surya Hotel in the heart of Varanasi had been booked by the BJP and converted into a media centre. No party is as proficient at courting the media as the BJP. The organization was near faultless. Dozens of computers, endless cups of chai and samosas, a room for interviews to be conducted—keeping the large media contingent in good humour came easy to the BJP. I must confess I was a little surprised,